

Annotation Guidelines

Project 002 – Sentiment Analysis

1. Purpose

The purpose of this annotation project is to classify customer feedback according to its overall sentiment while maintaining consistency across diverse domains and varying levels of sentiment complexity. The dataset is intended to simulate real world sentiment annotation tasks used to train and evaluate Natural Language Processing (NLP) models for customer feedback analysis.

2. Annotation Task

Each customer message must be assigned **one** of the following labels:

- Positive
- Negative
- Neutral
- Mixed

Annotators should classify the **overall sentiment** expressed by the customer rather than isolated words or phrases.

3. Label Definitions

▪ Positive

Assign **Positive** when the customer expresses satisfaction, approval, praise, appreciation, or a favorable opinion regarding a product, service, or experience.

Examples:

- "The staff were incredibly helpful."
 - "Everything arrived earlier than expected."
 - "The latest update fixed all the issues."
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▪ Negative

Assign **Negative** when the customer expresses dissatisfaction, frustration, disappointment, criticism, or reports a predominantly unfavorable experience.

Examples:

- "The product stopped working after two days."
 - "Customer support never replied."
 - "I regret buying this phone."
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▪ **Neutral**

Assign **Neutral** when the message communicates factual information or a status update without expressing a clear opinion or emotional evaluation.

Examples:

- "Your payment has been received."
 - "The meeting has been moved to Friday."
 - "My application is under review."
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▪ **Mixed**

Assign **Mixed** when both positive and negative opinions make meaningful contributions to the overall message and neither clearly dominates.

Examples:

- "The food was delicious, but the service was slow."
 - "The battery lasts all day, although the camera struggles in low light."
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4. General Annotation Rules

- **Rule 1:** Annotate the customer's **overall message**, not individual words.
 - **Rule 2:** Do not rely solely on emotionally charged vocabulary. Instead, evaluate the complete customer experience being described.
 - **Rule 3:** Avoid making assumptions that are not supported by the text. Annotate only what is explicitly stated or clearly implied.
 - **Rule 4:** When multiple opinions are expressed, determine whether both sentiments materially contribute (**Mixed**), or one sentiment clearly dominates (**Positive** or **Negative**).
 - **Rule 5:** Context matters. A sentence containing the word "**but**" is **not automatically Mixed**. Evaluate the relationship between both clauses before assigning a label.
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5. Adjudication Principles

The following principles were established during reviewer calibration and applied consistently throughout the project.

5.1 Status Updates vs Sentiment

Successful completion of an action does not automatically indicate Positive sentiment.

Examples of **Neutral**:

- Payment received
- Password changed
- Application under review
- Shipment in transit

Positive sentiment requires an evaluation of the experience rather than confirmation that an action occurred.

5.2 Core Functionality vs Secondary Attributes

When evaluating products, distinguish between:

- primary functional expectations
- secondary or cosmetic characteristics

Failure of a core functional feature may justify a **Negative** label even if secondary positive attributes are acknowledged.

Example:

- attractive appearance
- poor functionality

Overall: Negative

5.3 Expectation Violations

Expressions indicating that a product or service failed to meet expectations strengthen Negative sentiment.

Common indicators include:

- "Worse than advertised"
- "Not what I expected"
- "Disappointing for the price"

- "Slower than promised"

5.4 Service Recovery

When a problem occurs but is followed by effective recovery, determine whether the recovery outweighs the initial failure.

Examples:

Positive:

- Immediate apology
- Fast replacement
- Exceptional customer service

Mixed:

- Delay with proactive communication
- Product issue resolved after inconvenience

Negative:

- Resolution only restores expected functionality after repeated customer effort.

5.5 Restoration vs Enhancement

Restoring expected functionality after repeated effort should not automatically be interpreted as Positive.

Examples:

- Router works after multiple restarts.
- Issue resolved after repeated customer contacts.

The restoration returns the service to its expected baseline but does not necessarily improve the overall customer experience.

5.6 Evidence-Based Annotation

Annotation decisions should be supported by evidence from the text. Avoid speculative reasoning or assumptions regarding the customer's emotions unless clearly expressed or implied.

6. Difficult Cases

When uncertain:

- Identify whether an opinion is expressed.
- Determine whether multiple sentiments are present.
- Evaluate whether one sentiment dominates.
- Consider whether expectations were met or violated.
- Select the label most consistent with previous annotations.

7. Annotation Workflow

- Review the customer message.
- Identify sentiment indicators.
- Apply the annotation guidelines.
- Document rationale for ambiguous cases.
- Perform QA review.
- Resolve disagreements through adjudication.
- Finalize the annotation.

Note: Reliable sentiment annotation requires consistent interpretation of customer intent, expectation management, and contextual reasoning.